Sitting under the yellow haze of the hotel's wall lamp, Anupam Kher talks gently about grief, an emotion that is every mortal being's ill-fated companion. Kher acknowledges grief with sincerity. He knows that tragedy never works around a timetable; things get broken, and the anguish of loss is perennial. Grief is palpable, tangible and, sadly, everywhere.

That evening, grief was not a coincidental conversation starter; it lay at the heart of Kher's 540th film *Calorie*, which had its international premiere at the 56th International Film Festival of India (IFFI), Goa, in the prestigious Cinema of the World category. *Calorie* does not borrow grief from imagination; it stems from real-life tragedy and the personal bereavement of Eisha Marjara, the film's writer and director, the 1985 bombing of Air India flight 182, which exploded mid-air killing all 329 passengers. Marjara's mother and younger sister left Montreal for India and were killed on that flight.

2025 marks the 40th anniversary of the bombing—a tragedy that inevitably left an indelible imprint on Marjara, her family, and on the families and friends of the victims. When Kher was approached to play Mohan Singh in Calorie, he was drawn to the honesty and emotional truth of Marjara's storytelling. "It had been nearly 40 years since the bombing, but the anguish of loss was inescapable in her eyes," Kher reminisced.

"*Calorie* is a deeply human story that goes beyond borders. It captures the intersection of culture and belonging, blending the universal themes of family, love and loss. Conflict is at the heart of filmmaking, and these stories must be told. Perhaps, for the storyteller, filmmaker, these stories are cathartic, a medium to purge the remnants of loss that often moulder in an invisible corner of our hearts," Kher elaborated.

Calorie traces three generations of women as they confront their shared past and buried secrets during a transformative summer in India



SHARED SILENCES
A scene from *Calorie*

COMPASS PRODUCTIONS/KETANN MEHTA

Calorie traces three generations of women as they confront their shared past and buried secrets during a transformative summer in India. The story follows Monika, a stressed single mother who sends her two teenage daughters to visit their relatives in India, hoping the trip will reconnect them with their Punjabi roots. What begins as a reluctant visit soon unravels into a powerful journey of identity, healing, and rediscovery across continents and generations.

Calorie seems an anomalous title for an intergenerational story that excavates the complicated and entangled relationship daughters have with their mothers. But the title is not referring to the standard unit of energy in nutrition; instead, it is a metaphorical title, referring to themes of energy, consumption, nourishment, or the emotional 'weight' of the family's past.

"Forty-one years as an actor and 540 films. How would you define Mohan Singh?" I ask Kher. Sitting cross-legged on a beige sofa, Kher brought grief back to the colloquy. "Grief set my filmography in motion with Saaransh (1984), the despair of B.B. Pradhan, a retired headmaster, confronting the tragedy of his only son's